

PASSES AND BLITZES

by Gwannon

«Passes and Blitzes» is a hack for the role-playing game "«Lasers & Feelings» created by John Harper.

It's the final play of the most important American football (aka Blood Bowl) match of your lives. Your team is losing, but if you play your cards right, you can achieve the glory reserved for the winners of the Blood Cup.

To play this game, you'll need paper, a pencil, and three six-sided dice (d6). A game typically lasts about one hour to two hours.

PC: CREATE YOUR STARPLAYER

TEAM CREATION

The first step is to create your team. To do this, you need to define three elements:

Name. Names usually have two parts: a denominator, like the Reapers, the Ruffians, or the Nightmares, and then their place of origin, such as the Dark Forest, Khazad Nûm, Riverland, etc.

Predominant Species. The species can be any fantasy species like dwarves, elves, gnomes, orcs, etc. or even science fiction - cyborgs, aliens, etc. It doesn't matter.

Playing Style. You must choose whether you are a rough or technical team. If your team is technical, their game is based on strategy, spectacular strategies, and passing, receiving, and long runs. If your team is rough, your style is to crush the

opposing team without mercy. *This decision will affect the creation of your starplayer.*

PLAYER CREATION

Your star player's species should match the team's species. You can also allow compatible species. It's not uncommon to see goblins on orc teams or gnomes on elf teams.

Next, you must give them a **name**. Also, choose **pronouns**.

If your team is **rough**, choose a number **between 2 and 4**, and if it's **technical**, **between 3 and 5**. A high number means you're better at PASSING (everything related to skill and intelligence: throwing, receiving, dodging, jumping, and also tactics and deception). A low number means you're better at BLOCKING (everything related to strength and stamina: blocking, pushing, charging, running, tackling, and also fear and intimidation).





When you arrive into the field, you have your **basic equipment**: protective gear (chest protector, shoulder pads, elbow pads, gauntlets, knee pads, gloves, boots, and helmet). If you're a rough player, your gear is usually heavy, durable, and spiked, while if you're a technical player, it's usually lightweight, compact, and allows for freedom of movement.

Finally, you must choose a position on the team: lineman, blocker, thrower, catcher, or blitzer.

THE FREE AGENT, THE VETERAN, AND THE BRILLIANT ROOKIE

Every team has in their crew three archetypes that define its character: the free agent, the veteran, and the brilliant rookie. Your players can choose any of these archetypes if they wish.

The **brilliant rookie is a newcomer who knows nothing** yet thinks he knows it all. He wants to stand out and win at all costs - a drive that makes him reckless, a trait that could cost him his career in this sport.

The **veteran has seen it all** and knows, above all, that this will be his final season. His aging body is crying out for rest; the toll of too many Orc blockers standing in his path has taken its price.

The **free agent is a mercenary** who might be on an orc team today and an elf team tomorrow. He is star - and knows it - and loves to shine, as doing so drives up his rates.

The rule limiting your skill level based on whether the team is "rough" or "technical" can be bypassed by two of your players if they choose to be the rookie or the free agent. In those cases, they can choose a skill level between 2 and 5.

They do not necessarily have to belong to the team's predominant species - especially the free agent.

POSITION AND PLAYING STYLE

When you roll a "Passes and Blitzes" result, you can perform a **Heroic Action** during the next action, depending on your position within the team.

LINEMAN

You are the most basic player; your mission is to help the others and serve as cannon fodder - that's just how it is. You are playing unique comeback scenarios; this is not the time to play a lineman. It is advisable - though not mandatory - to avoid choosing this position. **You have no heroic action**; you are there solely to support other players so they can shine.

BLOCKER

You are a bloodthirsty beast who finishes every match covered in the blood of your opponents - and often your own. You could spend weeks telling the story behind every scar on your body, but that doesn't satisfy you the way it used to; you want something more - perhaps to score a touchdown, make a spectacular run...

Using your **Frenzy Block**, you can hurl yourself at multiple opponents and knock them down, or even go toe-to-toe with a big guy.

THROWER

Typically, there is only one thrower per team; you could be the veteran looking to bow out in a blaze of glory.

Or perhaps the rookie who just stepped in because the starting thrower lost his throwing arm - severely mauled by a rabid goblin - and is eager to prove he's got star potential.

With a **Hail Mary pass**, you can attempt a wild pass to a teammate even when surrounded by opponents, blinded by the rain, and battling hurricane-force winds. If your teammate manages an **epic reception** to snag that impossible pass, it could be a play that goes down in history.

CATCHER

Your game is all about dodging, breaking free, sprinting, leaping, and having sure hands. The moment you get caught, you're mincemeat - but you're harder to grab than a greased pig. Free agents and veterans rarely play catcher; that position is often reserved for the rookie - the little guy who makes up for a lack of size and strength with courage and agility.

With your **epic reception**, you can make a desperate sprint&jump to catch an impossible pass, disregarding your own physical safety. But it doesn't have to end there; that reception might transition into an acrobatic tumble that lets you evade defenders, or see you landing in the mud and sliding all the way to the goal line.

BLITZER

You are a strange mixture of blocker and catcher, strong and agile, yet often a lone wolf. This role is typically suited to free agents who stand out for their individualism, or to veterans possessing

the experience and savvy to excel in the position.

Your **heroic run** allows you to charge forward with the ball; praying to your gods and relying on a mix of blocking and dodging, you might just make it to the goal line. You will likely launch yourself at the last moment, soaring over the defenders to reach the end zone with a spectacular leap that leaves the crowd speechless at what they have just witnessed.

DICE ROLLS

When you do something risky, roll 1d6 to find out how it goes. Roll +1d if you're prepared (standing in position on the field, at the right moment, and, if it's possible, without opponents nearby) and +1d6 if it falls within the normal capabilities of your position (the GM will tell you how many dice you can roll, based on your position). Roll the dice and compare each result to the number you chose.

If you're using PASSES, you want to roll under your number. If you're using BLITZES, you want to roll over your number.

1. If **none of your dice succeed**, it goes wrong. The GM says how things get worse somehow.
2. If **one die succeeds**, you barely manage it. The GM inflicts a complication, harm, or cost.
3. If **two dice succeed**, you do it well. Good job!
4. If **three dice succeed**, you get a critical success! The GM will grant you some **extra benefit** which will typically be linked to your position. Perhaps you've made an uninterceptable launch, or you find yourself all alone with no one around when receiving a pass.

5. If you roll **exactly your number**, you gain PASSES BLITZES. You notice something special happening during the match. Ask the DJ a question, and they will give you an honest answer. Some interesting questions: What strategy do they seem to have? Do they seem to have a trick up their sleeve? Do they consider me a threat? Are they coming for me or the ball? Can I safely throw the ball? Can I knock him down? You may change your action based on this new information; if you do, roll again. As part of that new action, you can use your position's **Heroic Action**, which also requires a roll.

ASSISTS

If you want to assist another player's roll, explain how you are doing it and roll the dice. If successful, you grant a +1d6 bonus. Generally, the assisting player must be in the same section of the field to provide support, though in some situations this is not required.

You cannot assist a player who shares your position, unless you are a Lineman, who can assist anyone. A Blocker can only assist other Blockers or the Thrower. Throwers and Catchers cannot assist each other either, as they are located in completely opposite sections of the field.

GM: WHEN EVERYONE THOUGHT IT WAS IMPOSSIBLE...

The last plays in "Passes and Blitzes" are easy to create using these simple tables, but feel free to create any play you think is best.

1D6 WEATHER

- 1 **Snow and ice.** The ground is frozen and slippery.
- 2 **Flash floods.** The field is a mud pit, making it very difficult to move and handle the ball.
- 3 **Heatwave.** Running is exhausting, and several players are sidelined with heatstroke.
- 4 **Perfect weather** for playing American football.
- 5 **Strong winds.** Passes become very inaccurate.
- 6 **Very sunny.** The sun often blinds you.

1D6 TEAM SUPPORTERS

- Bring-your-offspring-to-the-match day. The opposing team's section is packed with excited siblings, while your side is full of sad little faces. No matter what happens, there will be sad faces on sad children.
- 1 Free tickets were handed out, and the stadium is full of people who don't really know what's going on.
 - 2 Violent, drunken hooligans.
 - 3 There is a fierce rivalry, and both sets of fans have been brawling throughout the match.
 - 4 The spectators are bored and paying no attention to the game; there's even a goblin who has pulled out a book and started reading.
 - 5 A bored Chaos god and his entourage have decided to watch a match.
 - 6

The hooligans belong to the same species as your players' team and the opposing team, and they might get along or be mortal enemies.

1D6 OPPOSING TEAM

- 1 Dwarves, elves, halflings, gnomes
- 2 Orcs, goblins, hobgoblins
- 3 Humans, norses, bretons
- 4 Dark elves, chaos dwarves, halfords
- 5 Lizard people, rat people, beast people
- 6 Undeads, vampires, mummies

1D6 ILLEGAL EQUIPMENT, TRAPS, CHEATS AND TRICKS

- 1 Dwarven Steamroller
- 2 Sniper hidden on the stadium roof
- 3 Wizard hidden among the audience
- 4 Chainsaw, ball&chain, ball-launching blunderbuss
- 5 It's a trap: spike pit, bear trap, anti-personnel mines
- 6 TBig guys: Trolls, treepeople, ogres, minotaurs

1D6 HOW IS THE MATCH GOING?

- If you score on this final play, the cup is yours. You are tired, injured, and
- 1 demoralized, but no one said this would be easy. The people who laughed at you all season are about to see what you're made of.
 - 2 Strangely, all the team's regulars have fallen victim to a curse after the break and are unable to play. You've been called up from the very end of the bench, and this is your only chance to shine and secure a permanent spot on the team.
 - 3 You are the last players on your team who are literally still alive. If you hold out until time runs out, you win the match.
 - 4 You are on defense and losing. They are likely to hold onto the ball until the match ends. You need to come up with a wild, suicidal strategy to steal the ball and score.
- You accepted bribes to lost the game, but at the last moment, you decide you'd rather have the glory of victory. That means the assassins and mercenary mages -
- 5 hired by the local mobster just in case you backed out - are coming into play. There is almost certainly a price on your heads, so the opposing team is going to pull out all the stops.
 - 6 Tempers are flaring, and the crowd is on the verge of pitch invasion. Scoring isn't impossible, but once you do, you don't expect to make it out of the pitch invasion alive.



GM: HOW TO MASTER

As we've already mentioned, **you won't be playing a full match, just that final epic play** where your players want to prove they aren't the losers everyone thinks they are. So, these last an hour at most.

The first thing you need to do is explain their situation: the score deficit, the opposing team, the weather conditions and how many yards they are from the goal line.

It must be a desperate situation, perhaps they have to score a desperate goal to win or simply survive the final quarter to avoid disqualification for lacking enough players. Maybe they need to lose by fewer than five points so the team's evil owner loses a bet, or perhaps the entire opposing team has been bought off, except for your players,

forcing them to take on both teams just to score.

To sum up, whatever it is, it needs to sound sportingly epic.

Next up is the team huddle; your players crouch down and gather in a circle to talk. Let them choose from some of these options:

1. Encouraging one another.
2. Someone make a motivational speech.
3. Someone comes up with a brilliant idea to win.
4. A plan is proposed to cheat in order to win.

Once that is done, they take their positions and wait for the referee's whistle. This might be a good moment to describe the situation in greater detail, the state of the fans and the opposing team, the condition of the pitch, and the weather, so they can form a mental picture of what they are up against.

COMPLICATIONS

An adventure of this game is essentially a series of complications that your players must resolve somehow. These complications don't have to come solely from the opposing team.

It's not all about "bloodthirsty maniacs charging at you"; there are plenty of other complications. Something as simple as being knocked down counts as a complication, especially if a Dwarven Steamroller or a troll trying to throw a goblin are near you.

The weather can be a complication, rain can be very troublesome, but a skilled player can try to dodge opponents by sliding across the water.



The referee can also be a complication, maybe he's been bought off, is blind as a bat, is more interested in eating a hot dog than the game or is angry with the rookie because the rookie stole their date at the local bar the night before.

The public also presents an interesting complication, not just the opposing team's fans, but your own as well. Boos and shouts of "Get off the field, you bum! You're all thumbs and have two left feet" sting just as much as a block in the line of scrimmage. They might throw objects, run onto the field to steal the ball, or even stage a pitch invasion. And don't forget: if the team wins, those same fans will rush the field to hoist the players onto their shoulders in triumph.

Finally, **insert in your session every crazy idea you can think of**: explosive balls, marksman with crossbows, flying advertising ships that crash onto the field, spike traps, seductive cheerleaders who distract you with their chants and dances, surprise appearances by legends of the sport, or dogs that run onto the pitch and steal the ball.

It is important to avoid repetition; perhaps you could have three distinct waves of opponents facing your blitz: the first could be standard, the second might include an enemy wielding a ball and chain, and the third could be a ravenous minotaur. This way, the level of difficulty remains essentially the same, yet the player must confront each encounter in a different way.

GETTING CLOSER AND WITH LESS TIME

Time and space are relative and ruled by the epicness. Yards can be stretched or shrunk to suit your needs and heighten the drama. If the teams are close, they'll be just

a few yards away, meaning any failure leaves them right near the goal line; whereas if they are far apart, every inch of progress will be a grueling battle of blood and sweat.

Keep a simple record of the yardage so your players can easily tell how close they are to their target; remember that measurements are in 10-yard blocks and half the field is 120 yards.

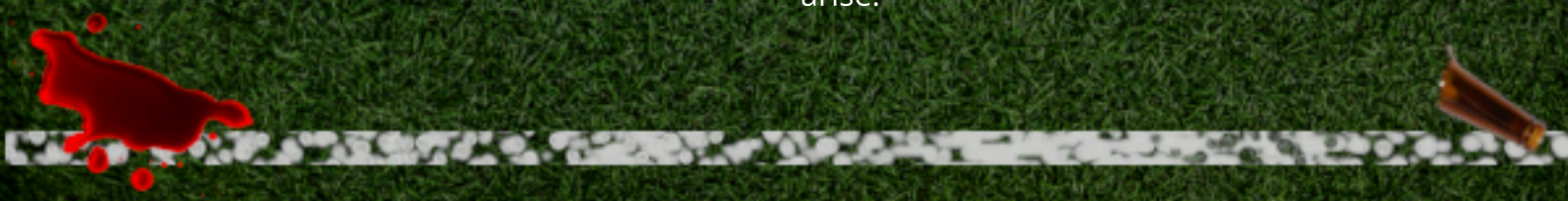
The same thing can happen over time. A super-long pass can be instantaneous or allow your players to perform multiple actions in an attempt to pull off that legendary play they never thought would work.

And if time and space bend to your will, so do your enemies. Bring out as many as you like; if you realize you've gone overboard, you can always explain it away by saying a wizard teleported them in, that they were cheating and there were extra players on the field, or even that they were just random interlopers from the crowd.

OTHER CONSIDERATIONS

Communication is difficult: fans are shouting, beer vendors are shouting, your opponents are shouting, cheerleaders are shouting... In short, the noise is deafening. Consequently, communication between your players would have to be done by shouting (though they can speak normally—there is no need to scream), but anything they shout will be heard by the other players. They might be able to use hand signals, but only for very basic things.

The field has two zones: the front and the back. The thrower is usually always at the back, while the catcher moves around primarily. The rest (stands, benches, ...) are simply areas where complications can arise.





If your players seem stuck, you can use a fun visual trick: when they suffer a major setback—like being knocked to the ground—time slows down, giving them a moment to examine something they might have overlooked or perhaps relive a memory that sparks an idea for how to move forward.

The epicness is a vital part of sport and this game; encourage your players to embrace it and attempt the impossible—and if the gods of American football (and the dice) allow it, they will pull off truly heroic sporting feats in the final seconds.

If you're feeling inspired, you can try **play-by-play commentary** as the GM, narrating the action like a sports broadcaster, whether you're introducing complications

or describing the results of actions and rolls. Use phrases like "Against all odds...", "This is incredible!", "In all my years of commentary, I've never...", or "When no one gave a dime for...", among others.

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